

Mexico



Mexico stretches from the US border southward into the ancient Aztec and Mayan heartlands. Independence from Spain came in 1836. One in five Mexicans lives in the sprawling capital.



GEOGRAPHY

Coastal plains along the Pacific and Atlantic seabords rise to a high arid central plateau. To the east and west are the Sierra Madre mountain ranges. Limestone lowlands form the projecting Yucatan peninsula.



CLIMATE

The plateau and high mountains are warm for much of the year. Pacific coast is tropical: storms occur mostly March–December. Northwest is dry.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most Mexicans are *mestizos* of Spanish–Amerindian descent. Rural Amerindians are largely segregated from Hispanic society and most live in poverty, though the state promotes their culture. The Zapatista movement backs indigenous rights. Few women in male-dominated politics and business. Narcotics-related violent crime is rising.



THE ECONOMY

One of the world's largest oil producers. Corn, fruit, vegetables, sugar are cash crops. NAFTA has boosted exports, but exposes farmers to subsidized US competition. Huge wealth disparity. Swine flu crippled economy in 2009.



INSIGHT: *More people cross the US–Mexican border each year – illegally or legally – than any other border in the world*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: United Mexican States

DATE OF FORMATION: 1836

CAPITAL: Mexico City

POPULATION: 110 million

TOTAL AREA: 761,602 sq. miles
(1,972,550 sq. km)

DENSITY: 149 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, Nahuatl, Mayan, Zapotec, Mixtec, Otomi, Totonac, other

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 88%, other 7%, Protestant 5%

ETHNIC MIX: *Mestizo* 60%, Amerindian 30%, European 9%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Mexican peso = 100 centavos